



AP

THE FILM'S CAST AT THE KODAK THEATRE

|2009| INDIA'S OSCAR MOMENT The Million Dollar Dream

Slumdog Millionaire's Oscar sweep was a boost to Brand India

In January this year, when Freida Pinto was striking her perfected red carpet pose dressed in Chanel and Oscar De La Renta, her co-stars in Mumbai were courting publicity of a different kind. Rubina Ali and Azharuddin Mohammad Ismail, the two slum children who played young Latika and Salim in Danny Boyle's *Slumdog Millionaire*, could not fathom the flurry of cameras and news crew outside their makeshift shanties in the ironically named Garib Nagar. Up until the reporters showed up, they had no idea that the small \$15-million film, for which they shot over a year ago and had already spent the Rs 1 lakh they received for 35 days of shooting, had become the toast of every award show, putting the focus on India at large, and them in particular. These two children along with Ayush Khedekar, who played Jamal, had never imagined that their lives would become a rags-to-red-carpet story. As rumours about Rubina and Ismail having been short-changed on remuneration grew louder, comparisons were drawn to Mira Nair's *Salaam Bombay* that had similarly cast slum children. As *Slumdog Millionaire's* Oscar prospects started shining after its Golden Globe sweep, the two children were promised flats and better education. On the morning of February 23, as Indians woke up to their Oscar-tuned alarms, it was these three pint-sized children who had the international paparazzi going hysterical. And when the entire team of the film ran up to hold the statuette, India's Oscar moment reached its crescendo. Returning home after a fairy-tale week, Ayush became an advertisement favourite and after waiting for months, Rubina and Azhar moved into their government-allotted flats in Santa Cruz and are now studying in an English medium school for underprivileged children, Aseema. And to think that the original distributors Warner Bros, doubting the film's money-making prospects, had once suggested that the film go straight to DVD. Today, it has earned over \$370 million, made Pinto India's real Hollywood export, given Anil Kapoor a role in the hit series *24* and turned the lives of its two slum children on its head. *by Jhilmil Motihar*

THE MAIN EVENT

UPA II

Clichéd as it may sound, the big winner of the General Elections 2009 is the common man for having delivered a verdict that will not give the Congress any excuses for non-performance now. What worked for the party was Rahul Gandhi's high decibel campaigns and well-publicised and well-packaged 'Discovery of India' tours. Of the UPA's policies, the NREGS was the most well-publicised and well-acknowledged programmes followed by the farm loan waivers. Extreme politics—Left or Right—have no relevance in Indian democracy and the BJP and Left have a lot to learn. The people of India, cutting across socio-economic strata, are looking for opportunities and level playing fields, not state patronage that keeps them poor, backward and ignorant.

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SONIA GANDHI (LEFT) AND MANMOHAN SINGH

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A \$15-MILLION FILM, SLUMDOG MILLIONAIRE HAS SO FAR EARNED OVER \$370 MILLION.